

What is music?

We create music by organizing sounds. All around the world people make music to accompany their lives—singing, playing musical instruments, finding rhythms, melodies, and combinations of sounds.

The origins of music

Music began with singing, with percussive sounds using wood, stone, and animal skins, and with flutes made from bamboo or other suitable plants. We began by imitating natural sounds—birdsong especially—just as the earliest painters drew the animals they saw.

▷ Lyre

Among the first string instruments to be developed, lyres were popular in Egypt and Mesopotamia, and later in ancient Greece.



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▷ Chinese pellet drum

A pellet drum has two heads, and two pellets, or hard beads, each connected to the drum by a cord. The beads strike the drum alternately when it twists back and forth.

The sounds around us

Many sounds such as wind, rain, and thunder occur naturally. Others are made by animals and birds, or by us when we breathe, laugh, or cry. There are accidental sounds, the by-products of work, the sounds of machines, of footsteps on a pavement, or the sound of marching soldiers. Musicians often draw on such sounds for inspiration, imitating them with voices or instruments.

◁ Creating music

We create music by organizing sounds in different ways to make melody, harmony, and rhythm. There are always new ways of combining and shaping sounds.

MELODY

Melody concerns pitch—how high or low the notes are. A melody is formed when a sequence of notes of varying pitch is played or sung.

HARMONY

Harmony is what we get when different notes (notes of different pitch) are produced at the same time. Different combinations of pitches can be consonant (harmonious) or dissonant.

RHYTHM

Melody and rhythm are what we hear as the music moves forward in time. Rhythm concerns the duration of notes, and the way in which they are played or sung in relation to a regular beat or pulse.